



ICONOGRAPHY OF FESTIVE INDIA

Here's how contemporary design is reinterpreting traditional Indian iconography for the modern home

By KRSNAA MEHTA

Festive India has never been about following a single aesthetic. It has always been about abundance, emotion and expression, a language built through colour, light, flowers, textiles, food, patterns and objects that carry memories. What is interesting today is how these familiar symbols of celebration are finding new expressions within contemporary homes. We are not moving away from tradition; we are finding new ways to make it our own.

I believe the festive home should feel layered, lived-in and deeply personal. There is something beautiful about bringing together different colours, textiles, cushions and throws and allowing them to build warmth and depth. Festivity does not always need to mean adding more. It can be about bringing together elements that already have meaning and creating a richer visual story. Most interesting spaces are often those where different influences co-exist naturally.



Light has always been one of India's most powerful festive symbols. Diyas, lamps, candles, flowers and garlands can completely transform the feeling of space. Their significance goes beyond decoration; they create warmth, atmosphere and a sense of occasion. Even the simplest cluster of diyas or a thoughtfully placed floral arrangement can make a home feel instantly celebratory. But the way we use them can evolve with the spaces we live in today.

Our walls offer another canvas for this expression. Indian motifs, patterns and stories have an incredible visual vocabulary and wallpapers and wall art allow us to reinterpret these influences in ways that feel contemporary. The idea is not to recreate the past exactly as it was, but to take what is familiar and give it a new context. That is where I think contemporary Indian design becomes particularly exciting when heritage is a starting point rather than a limitation.

The festive table is where design and celebration truly come together. Dinnerware, serve ware and glassware become part of the experience, sitting alongside the food, sweets and rituals that bring people together. For me, a beautifully set table is not about perfection; it is about creating an environment that encourages people to linger, talk, share and celebrate. The table becomes an extension of hospitality and, in many ways, one of the most personal expressions of how we welcome people into our homes.

Then there are the objects that make a home unmistakably yours. An artefact picked up while travelling, a family object, a collectible or a statement piece can hold a memory and become part of the story of a home. These personal details are what transform festive décor from something styled into something lived.

Ultimately, the art of festive decorating is the art of bringing people together. The most beautiful festive homes are not necessarily perfectly decorated ones. They are the ones that feel warm, expressive and ready to welcome the people who matter. Festive India has always had its own iconography. Today, we have the opportunity to reinterpret it through our own lens bringing together heritage and individuality, tradition and contemporary design.